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Haman

The proud official who plotted to destroy the Jews and was hanged on the gallows he built for Mordecai.

Haman was the most powerful official at the Persian court. King Ahasuerus promoted him above all the other princes and ordered everyone to bow to him. One man, Mordecai the Jew, would not. Haman's wounded pride grew into a plan to kill every Jew in the empire. He cast lots to choose the day, offered the king a fortune in silver, and got the decree sealed with the king's own ring. Yet Haman's plans turned against him at every step. He was made to honour the very man he hated, and he was exposed at Queen Esther's banquet. In the end he was hanged on his own gallows. His story shows how pride and hatred can destroy the one who carries them.

At a glance

Name	Probably Persian or Elamite. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Hammedatha the Agagite; wife Zeresh; ten sons (Esther 3:1; 5:10; 9:7–10)
Position	Chief of the king's princes, with his seat set above them all (Esther 3:1)
Known as	"The Jews' enemy" (Esther 3:10; 8:1; 9:24)
When	In the reign of Ahasuerus (usually Xerxes I). His plot came in the king's 12th year, c. 474 BC
Death	Hanged on the gallows he had made for Mordecai (Esther 7:10)
New Testament	Not named

"So they hanged Haman on the gallows that he had prepared for Mordecai. Then was the king's wrath pacified."

Esther 7:10, KJV

The life of Haman

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the usual identification of Ahasuerus with Xerxes I (486–465 BC). Esther 3–7 covers less than a year of Haman's life.

Before c. 474 BC Promoted	● Raised above all the princes King Ahasuerus promotes Haman, son of Hammedatha the Agagite, and sets his seat above all the princes. The king commands his servants at the gate to bow before him. Mordecai refuses. <i>Esther 3:1–4</i>
c. 474 BC 12th year, 1st month	● The plot Full of wrath, Haman decides to destroy all Mordecai's people. Lots are cast to choose the day. He offers ten thousand talents of silver, and the king gives him his ring. <i>Esther 3:5–11</i>
c. 474 BC 13th day, 1st month	● The decree Letters go out to every province ordering all Jews killed on the thirteenth of Adar. Then "the king and Haman sat down to drink; but the city Shushan was perplexed." <i>Esther 3:12–15</i>
The first banquet	● Gallows for Mordecai Haman leaves the queen's banquet overjoyed, until he sees Mordecai at the gate, who will not stand up for him. At home his wife and friends advise a gallows fifty cubits high. He has it built. <i>Esther 5:9–14</i>
The next day	● Forced to honour Mordecai Haman comes to ask for Mordecai's death, but the king asks him how to honour a man. Thinking he means himself, Haman describes a royal parade and must then lead Mordecai through the streets. <i>Esther 6:4–13</i>
The second banquet	● Exposed and hanged At the second banquet Esther names "this wicked Haman" as the enemy of her people. He falls on her couch begging for his life, but the king orders him hanged on his own gallows. <i>Esther 7:1–10</i>

Key activities

Haman is called "the Agagite." Many readers link this to Agag, king of the Amalekites, whom Saul spared (1 Samuel 15:8–9). That would make his hatred part of an ancient feud between Amalek and Israel. Others think "Agagite" names a Persian family or place.

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- 1 **Rose to power.** The king promoted him and set his seat above all the princes. *Esther 3:1*
 - 2 **Demanded honour.** He was full of wrath when Mordecai did not bow. *Esther 3:2–5*
 - 3 **Hated a whole people.** He "thought scorn to lay hands on Mordecai alone" and set out to destroy all the Jews. *Esther 3:6*
 - 4 **Slandered and bribed.** He told the king that "a certain people" did not keep the king's laws, and he offered to pay for their destruction. *Esther 3:8–9*
 - 5 **Drank while the city was troubled.** After the decree went out, he sat down to drink with the king while Shushan was left in confusion. *Esther 3:15*
 - 6 **Could not enjoy success.** He boasted of his riches and his sons, then said, "Yet all this availeth me nothing, so long as I see Mordecai the Jew." *Esther 5:11–13*
 - 7 **Assumed the honour was his.** He thought, "To whom would the king delight to do honour more than to myself?" *Esther 6:6*
 - 8 **Fell on his own trap.** He was hanged on the gallows he had built, and his plot returned "upon his own head." *Esther 7:9–10; 9:25*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Haman.

Old Testament

Esther 3–7	This is the main account of his rise and fall.
Esther 8:1–7; 9:10–14, 24–25	His house is given to Esther, his decree is overturned, and his ten sons die.
Echoes	Saul spared Agag, king of the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15:8–9, 32–33). "He made a pit, and digged it, and is fallen into the ditch which he made" (Psalm 7:15). "Pride goeth before destruction" (Proverbs 16:18).

New Testament

Echoes	"Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap" (Galatians 6:7). "God resisteth the proud" (James 4:6). "Whosoever hateth his brother is a murderer" (1 John 3:15).
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For discussion

- Observe:* What did Haman say to his wife and friends about all his riches and honours (Esther 5:11–13)?
- Understand:* How did one man's refusal to bow grow into a plan to destroy a whole people? What does that show about pride and anger?
- Apply:* Is there one person or slight that you keep thinking about, the way Haman kept seeing Mordecai? What would it take to let it go?
- Apply:* Haman could not enjoy all he had. What good things in your life can you thank God for this week, instead of focusing on what is missing?